

June 1, 2026

Javier Tapia — Principal
Portola Charter Middle School (LAUSD)
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Dear Principal Tapia,

I am applying for the math teaching position at Portola Charter Middle School for the 2026-2027 school year. I bring a BSc in Mathematics and Computer Science from Brown — the academic foundation for the single-subject math pathway noted in your posting — fifteen years as a software engineer at Apple, Cisco, and Goldman Sachs, and five years founding and teaching at Dragon and Crane Dojo, a small private school I built from the ground up. I am turning toward LAUSD because I want to spend the next phase of my work in the place where my own trajectory began: a public school classroom.

Middle school is where students quietly decide whether math is for them, and a self-contained single-subject math classroom is where that decision is most often made. I have watched that decision form in slow motion across the off-the-mat curriculum I write and teach at my dojo — coding, chess, reading, physics — and I know how often the difference between "I can't" and "oh, I see it" comes down to one adult refusing to let a kid give up. At Dragon and Crane I have already done the work of sequencing multi-year curriculum, self-publishing student materials, and tracking individual progress, so the lesson-design and classroom-management muscles are not theoretical.

My industry background also lets me answer the question every math student eventually asks — when am I going to use this? I have used it: settlement systems at Goldman Sachs, network management APIs at Apple, clinical AI infrastructure at Deep6 AI. Math was not preparation for those jobs; it was the substance of them, and I want Portola's students to hear that from someone who has lived inside the answer.

Thank you for your consideration. I would welcome the opportunity to discuss how I can best serve Portola's students and families.

Sincerely,

David Chung
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